

Strengthening Women's Livelihoods and Household Nutrition in Arki Block

An integrated economic empowerment and maternal-child nutrition initiative for Scheduled Tribe women

Location: Arki Block (all 16 Gram Panchayats), Khunti District, Jharkhand

Duration: 24 months

Budget: INR 60,00,000

Submitted to: Grameen Vikas Foundation

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Problem Statement

Scheduled Tribe women of reproductive age in the landless and near-landless households of Arki block face two intertwined and mutually reinforcing challenges: economic vulnerability and a heavy burden of maternal and child undernutrition. Together these conditions hold households within a cycle of poverty and poor health that neither can break alone.

On the economic side, these women depend on rain-fed agriculture and the seasonal collection of forest produce, own little or no land, and have no stable off-farm income. Their earnings are consequently low and seasonally unstable, and their control over household income is limited. On the health and nutrition side, a majority of pregnant women are anaemic, and child stunting in the area ranks among the highest in the country. The two strands feed one another: poor income drives poor diets, while ill-health erodes the productivity and earning capacity on which better diets depend.

Project Objective

To strengthen the economic independence of 800 Scheduled Tribe women in Arki block by enabling stable and diversified incomes over which they exercise genuine control, while improving the maternal and child nutrition of their households through an integrated, mutually reinforcing set of interventions delivered over 24 months.

Operational Strategy

The project adopts an integrated, community-platform approach anchored in women's Self-Help Groups, which serve as the single delivery structure for both the economic and the health strands. Work is sequenced across three phases: mobilisation and group formation in the opening months, intensive capacity-building and asset support through the middle period, and consolidation, market linkage and transition toward self-sustaining institutions in the final phase.

Throughout, the project converges deliberately with government systems, the National Rural Livelihoods Mission, MGNREGA, the Integrated Child Development Services and the National Health Mission, so that its work reinforces, rather than duplicates, the entitlements and services already available to the community.

Activities

Activities are grouped by output and every activity traces to a defined result. Under the livelihoods outputs, the project mobilises women across all 16 Gram Panchayats, forms and strengthens Self-Help Groups, delivers skills training in selected trades, provides productive assets and input kits, and establishes market and financial-service linkages. Under the health and nutrition outputs, it trains community nutrition counsellors, conducts group and household counselling on maternal and child nutrition, establishes household kitchen gardens, and facilitates convergence with frontline health and nutrition services.

Results Framework

Level	Result statement	Indicator	Baseline	Target	Means of verification
Impact	Reduced intergenerational poverty and malnutrition among ST households in Arki block	Prevalence of stunting among under-5 children in beneficiary households	39.6% (NFHS-5, Jharkhand)	Trending below block baseline	Endline anthropometric survey; ICDS growth-monitoring records
Outcome 1	800 ST women have increased and diversified household incomes	Average annual income of beneficiary women; number of income sources per household	To be established by baseline survey	≥50% increase; ≥2 income sources	Baseline and endline income survey; SHG financial records
Outcome 2	Improved maternal and child nutrition practices in beneficiary households	Share of women achieving minimum dietary diversity	To be established	≥60% of women	Endline KAP survey; ICDS records
Output 1.1	Women trained in sustainable livelihood skills	Number of women completing training with ≥80% attendance	0	800 women	Training attendance registers; completion records
Output 2.2	Household kitchen gardens established	Number of functional gardens producing for ≥6 months	0	500 gardens	Field verification; harvest logs

Sustainability

Sustainability rests on four foundations. Institutionally, the Self-Help Groups are federated into Village Organisations that endure beyond the project team's presence. Financially, women retain access to capital through the savings, credit and bank linkages established during the project. Socially, the changed practices and strengthened capacities remain within the community. And through convergence, the work is handed to established public programmes designed to continue it.

Budget

Item	Unit	Unit cost	Qty	Total	Source
Project Coordinator	month	35,000	24	8,40,000	NRLM project-staff norms
Community Mobilisers (5)	month	15,000	24	18,00,000	Prevailing NGO field-staff rates, Jharkhand

Livelihood skills training	batch of 40	30,000	20	6,00,000	NRLM training cost norms
Kitchen garden input kits	household	1,500	500	7,50,000	[rate — confirm locally]
Goat units (2 does)	unit	12,000	100	12,00,000	State livestock scheme norms